

KF Mini-Meeting Lesson 5

--"MINI-MEETING" FORMAT-- (20 min)

I - MINDFULNESS (4 min)

-ANB (1 min)

-3 Minute Breathing Space (3 min)

II - CHECK-IN (10 min)

-KF Member "A" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

-KF Member "B" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

III - KF MEETING "PREVIEW" (6 min)

-Bible Teaching -- selected excerpt of upcoming KF Bible teaching (5 min)

-Ending Prayer (1 min)

BIBLE TEACHING

Let's go back to our beautiful passage in the first chapter of James. This is Nancy's translation, with a little paraphrase, of **James 1:2–4**.

²Guide yourselves into all joy, my siblings, when you fall into and are surrounded by all kinds of experiments, ³ knowing that the examination of what you truly trust and act upon results in the ability to remain under examination as it explores your ever-expanding potential. ⁴Give this growing ability of endurance a chance to accomplish its purpose, which is to make you a mature and complete person, lacking nothing, fully equipped for your joy and mission.

Take a deep breath.

Nancy's first point is often the most difficult to remember.

1. **The struggle is the valuable part** (*Repeat*)

If you learn one thing from this meeting, learn this: the struggle is the most important part of your process. Do not hesitate to get into the struggle. Well-managed struggling is how you become strong and skilled. If you exercise at the gym or are learning something new, you already know this.

In his famous book, *The Road Less Traveled*, Scott Peck begins with a troubling, but very true statement: *Life is difficult. (Repeat)* In other words, life is a struggle. Our problem is that we do not know how to struggle productively. We can only think of struggle as an unfair or purposeless kind of suffering. One of our most discouraging struggles is when we try to live loving lives but find ourselves driven by our compelling needs. In that struggle, we fear that our neurotic needs will go unmet. We also fear living with failure. Failure afflicts our pride system, and the pride system adds to the burden of our struggle.

When the Idol anticipates failure, our neurotic pride system is threatened, and we find that the terror of our self-hate is stronger and much more compelling than our commitment to love. If you have not been training, your love will be too weak to stand against the compulsive need to protect your pride. You will sacrifice your True Self and others in order to meet that need, and this will create a further burden of self-hate and fear in your soul. You might think that the way to overcome the unloving reactions of your pride and self-hate is simply to exercise more self-control, but you already know from experience that

your self-control is too weak and inconsistent to be reliable. The first step toward building a consistent loving life is to get rid of pride and learn to practice a gritty faith that stands against the Idol, fights it out, and trusts your Savior. As the fear of hurt pride and self-hate loses its grip, your struggles will become manageable and productive, and the love that God has already deposited in you will start to emerge.

2. The discovery and fostering of our True Self requires a lot of endurance

The ongoing discovery of your True Self begins with months of effort. Learning to dwell consistently in your True Self will take years of maintenance and support—in fact, it will take the rest of your life. Maintaining your physical health requires exactly the same intention; it requires courage and a sustained effort in a consistent direction. To build anything worthwhile, you need to learn the art of endurance. When you practice endurance, you grow in courage, and with more courage you can endure tension longer and with more productive results. You are an eternally developing creature designed to keep growing, and growth happens through endurance.

3. Let endurance do its work

What is endurance? The Greek word translated as *endurance* means to *remain under*. When you fall into an experiment, it is, as James says, an opportunity to see what skills you have, which areas need work, and how your character is developing. If you can manage the self-hate, you get to see the truth about yourself. If you can remain under the tension of your opportunity, you become creative—you explore, get help, and work on your connection to the Spirit. Through this process, you discover ways that cause less suffering, both for yourself and for others, and you experience more gratitude. Your compassion for yourself and others grows. You learn to lean more on God and less on your Idol Self.

4. Endurance trains us to be trustworthy

Finally, what is the goal of process of learning to endure through all of these experiments? The goal is to grow you up—to unify and fully equip you so that you have everything you need to accomplish your mission. You have a vital mission; God's reputation and the reputation of the believing community are in your hands. God cannot afford to entrust His redemptive purposes to untrustworthy people, so if you want to co-labor with Him to accomplish your mission, you must endure training to become trustworthy.

You may have been taught that the purpose of endurance and suffering is to fulfill some abstract and mysterious plan, but James teaches that endurance is designed to help YOU fulfill YOUR mission and design. Endurance helps YOU become wholly complete, integrated, and true, so that YOU who are alive in Christ are no longer forced to live in fear and subject to addictive, compulsive reactions to life. You may think that you lack this or that resource to accomplish your mission, but what do you really lack? You lack the health and orientation of the True Self—the self that circulates with God and with His Creation. If you focus on the restoration of your True Self and your orientation to God and His Creation, you will flourish and grow into your full potential, and you most certainly will lack nothing.

Our prayer might go something like this:

I need endurance training, Coach! (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are so grateful for this time together. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our glory and to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week and reorient our lives to a more effective flow, to furthering our connection with our True Self, with others, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.